



Born to be wild: Kaye Tefel holds the barred owl that was nursed back to health by the Carolina

Raptor Center before releasing it in McAlpine Greenway Park.

TOM FRANKLIN/Staff

Raptor Center nurses owl found tangled in fish line

By **PAT BORDEN GUBBINS**
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Somewhere along McDowell Creek in east Charlotte, there's one happy owl.

Early-morning visitors to McAlpine Greenway Park off Monroe Road might hear his song: "Who cooks for you? Who cooks for you all?"

That's the call of the barred owl, named for the brown- and white-feathered "bars" across his breast.

Last August, this particular owl had a very close call. As he was swooping through the trees along the creek bank, he was caught and trapped in a piece of fishing line.

He was found Aug. 23 dangling from a tree branch, the line wrapped around one wing and one of his feet.

"Evidently, someone had been down in the park fishing and got their line tangled in a tree," said park ranger Neil Carroll, who thinks the owl is male because of its small size. "The bird got tangled in the line and had injured its right wing."

Volunteer Rich Hubbard provided ambulance service. He took

the owl to the Carolina Raptor Center at Latta Plantation Park, where it received close attention for the next five and a half months.

"The main problem was the wing," said Mathias Engelmann, rehabilitation coordinator at the center for birds of prey. "We started treating it and put it on antibiotics. We gave it fluids and put a bandage on its wing. We gave it food and weighed it once a day, making sure it was eating on its own."

"We started some physical therapy on it to make sure the wing wouldn't get stiff while it was bandaged up," Engelmann said. "There was no damage to any of the bones or tendons, which was lucky. That could have been the end of it."

When the bandages came off, the owl was moved to a cage large enough to allow it to fly and rebuild strength in that wing.

On Friday, raptor center volunteer Kay Tefel released the owl near its old hunting grounds beside the creek while members of the rescue party and well-wishers looked on.